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An emerging donor in education and development: A case study of China in Cameroon

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ABSTRACT

This paper analyzes China's new approaches of education aid to Africa through a case study of Cameroon. China's cooperation has been characterized by different discourses and different historic relationships with recipient countries than those of traditional donors. Sino-African policies have gone through different stages, each connected to wider political and economic realities. Currently, a broadening of China's engagement with Africa can be noticed through increasing aid packages and the inclusion of African countries other than those that had traditionally been close to China. Cameroon has been one of the countries that have had a relatively extended cooperation with China. Four types of Chinese education aid to Africa are illustrated by this paper: (i) Confucius Institutes, which are providing language and culture-related training in host countries; (ii) longer term scholarships and short-term training for Africans in China; (iii) school construction; and (iv) stand-alone education projects. By analyzing how these three different types of aid are taking place in Cameroon, various and apparently contradictory strategies and discourses materialize.

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1. Introduction

The aim of this article is to discuss China's emergence as an aid donor in Africa, using its educational cooperation with Cameroon as a case study. China has been widely analyzed for its economic growth and visibility as an investor in the developing world from the time Deng Xiaoping started the reforms and opening-up policies. However, there has been less examination of China's new role as an aid donor.[1] Cameroon is an interesting case to exemplify China's engagement with Africa, since it has had a well-established diplomatic relationship with China for nearly 40 years, and the educational cooperation between the two countries possesses many characteristics that are helpful for the understanding of China's policies in Africa.

Research on China's education aid to Africa is different from researching other bilateral education aid, and its methodological challenges are substantial. Contrary to many other bilateral donors, there is no Chinese centralized institution responsible for international aid. A Department of Foreign Aid in China's Ministry of Commerce is the main coordinator for aid, and additionally, international units with elements of the external aid budget are connected to the Ministry of Education and several other ministries. Therefore, in China there is not a single unified development agency that can be researched (Davies et al., 2008; King, 2006). Despite the encouragement of the China–Africa Summit of 3–5 November 2006 in Beijing (FOCAC) to provide increased public access to essential data about Sino-African cooperation and aid, the documentation on Chinese aid to Africa remains scarce (Davies et al., 2008; Gill et al., 2007).

To better understand China's development strategies, this article will first provide a historic overview on Sino-African cooperation in education. Then, in a second section, it will explore China's bilateral educational cooperation with Cameroon. In particular, Chinese language education, school construction, capacity building and higher education research cooperation will be investigated. In a third section, the article will survey China's general cooperation policies in Cameroon and also present how government education staff, teachers, and education managers perceive them.

Key facets of Chinese educational aid to Africa can be found in the action plan from the Third and Fourth Forum of Sino-African Cooperation (FOCAC). The aid covers four main areas, including the provision of scholarships; setting up of rural schools; training of educational officials; and establishment of Confucius Institutes to teach the Chinese language (FOCAC, 2006; FOCAC, 2009a,b). Further, China has dispatched Chinese teachers to various African countries, has established research cooperation with a number of African Universities, and conversely also has established research centers on Africa in a number of Chinese Universities (He, 2006). A

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[1] See King (in press), Davies et al. (2008), and Davies (2007) for recent analysis of China as an aid donor to Africa.

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Fourth Forum on Sino-African Cooperation took place in Sharm El Sheikh, Egypt, in the end of 2009. Rather than changing the nature of China's policies towards Africa, the outcome of the new forum was said by Chinese officials (who I interviewed in Egypt prior to the conference) to represent a "consolidation" of the current 3-year phase. The outcome of the conference is summarized in the Declaration and Action Plans of the Sino-African Summit in Sharm El Sheikh, which purpose was to deepen "the new type of China–Africa Strategic Partnership for sustainable development" (FOCAC, 2009a, p. 1). The orientations of the Chinese education and development policies in Cameroon (and in other countries in Africa), in view of the outcomes of the fourth forum, are unlikely to undergo major changes over the next few years.

1.1. Methodology

This article is based on a research project funded by The Research Grants Council of Hong Kong (RGC) to study China's educational cooperation with Africa. In order to investigate China's resource bases for its African cooperation in education, I visited the Institute for African Studies at Zhejiang Normal University as well as aid- and cooperation-related institutions and organizations in Beijing in October 2008. I also conducted 2 weeks of fieldwork in Egypt in April 2009, during which I collected information about Sino-Egyptian cooperation in education, as well as on the Forth Forum on Sino-African Cooperation that was to take place in Sharm El Sheikh in November 2009. Fieldwork in Cameroon was conducted in January and February 2009, and resulted in 31 interviews. During fieldwork in Cameroon I conducted on-site interviews and group discussions, and consulted key informants, both Chinese and Cameroonian, with special knowledge about Sino-Cameroonian cooperation in education. The interviews were based on stratified sampling in an attempt to cover all aspects of Sino-Cameroonian cooperation in education, as follows: Confucius Institute teachers (four individual interviews); Chinese language students (11 students interviewed in two focus group settings and two individual interviews), professors and administrative personnel involved in Sino-African projects (three individual interviews), personnel from the Cameroonian Scholarship Commission (three individual interviews) and from the Cooperation Unit for Chinese and Japanese Projects (four individual interviews), as well as personnel from the Chinese Embassy (two individual interviews). Further, representatives from UNESCO (one interview), the Non-Governmental Network for Education For All (one individual interview), the Prime Minister's Office (one interview), and the Coordination Section at the Ministry of Higher Education (one interview). I conducted the interviews in English and French, and later transcribed them into English. Finally, I used a combination of methods to explore the case, including coding and analysis of interviews (using NVivo software) as well as the examination of various documentation collected in Cameroon, China and Egypt.

2. A historic perspective of Sino-African cooperation in education

Contemporary China's development policies towards Africa have gone through different stages, each connected to wider political and economic realities. I have used a phasing of the educational engagement inspired by Prof. He Wenping at the Institute of West Asian and African Studies (IWAAS) at the Chinese Academy of Social Sciences (CASS). According to He (2006), China's relations with Africa can be divided into three successive periods. I have labeled these three phases according to the main Chinese diplomatic preoccupations for Sino-African educational cooperation. Hence, the first period (1950–1989) can be seen as Sino-African cooperation with countries that are aligned with China's foreign policy and its socialist government philosophy (Tu, 2009). A second phase (1989–2000) was initiated with the events of Tiananmen Square in June 1989, and China's search for a broader political support in view of the country's relative isolation and criticism by the West. I have named the third phase according to the increasing economic relationships between China and Africa, and argue that presently, China's economic preoccupations bypass its traditional political alignments. It should be noted that I have used these labels for clarity. Political, security and commercial interests characterize all three periods, although at different intensity. As noted by Kwezi Kwaa Prah, the Director of the Centre for Advanced Studies of African Society (Cape Town):

> I wouldn't put it [the Sino-African relationship] in such polarized terms that at one end of the scale it is ideological and at the other it's all economic. I think what one can say is that it was preponderantly articulated and expressed in ideological terms in the earlier period. It also had economic dimensions but this was hardly pronounced. Now it is distinctly more pronounced as China tries to search for markets and also for raw materials (Prah and Burnett, 2007, p. 59).

An example of political interference in an otherwise economic-oriented document can be found, for example, in the recent Declaration of Sharm El Sheikh of the Forum on China–Africa Cooperation, in which the signatories "African countries reiterate their commitment to the one China policy and support for China's peaceful reunification [with Taiwan]" (FOCAC, 2009a, p. 4).

2.1. Period of political alignments (1950–1989)

During the period of political alignments (1950–1989), China's educational support to Africa was limited to the provision of scholarships to African students and to the dispatch of teachers to Africa to teach Chinese and basic educational courses such as mathematics, chemistry and physics. The period can be sub-divided into different phases, each corresponding to a different alignment of China's foreign policy. In the 1950s, China, with a pro-USSR and anti-US international policy, supported African communist parties and encouraged their struggle for independence (Li, 2006). During the Bandung Conference in April 1955 between Asian and African states to promote Afro-Asian political, economic and cultural cooperation, the initial steps for a closer relationship between China and African countries were taken. The first agreements of cooperation were signed with Algeria, Egypt, Guinea, Morocco and Sudan. In particular, China's dialogue with Egypt (one of the organizers of the Bandung conference – and later a main player in the Non-Aligned Movement) led to the beginning of an educational cooperation between the two countries. As a first modest step in 1956, four Egyptian students came to China to study and four Egyptian scholars went to China to lecture, while one English teacher and seven Chinese students were dispatched to Cairo (He, 2006).

In the 1960s, China engaged in a double policy of anti-revisionism and anti-imperialism, which led to a disruption of its relationships with some of the pro-USSR communist parties in Africa (e.g., South Africa). The period of the Cultural Revolution (1966–1976) coincided with a further isolation of China, and led to the breaking of diplomatic relationships with several African countries. The deterioration of diplomatic relationships had a direct and negative influence on educational cooperation: from 1967 to 1972, China did not receive African students (He, 2006). However, President Nixon's 1972 visit to China, which was

followed by the adoption of the Shanghai Communiqué[2] and the normalization of the relationship between the USA and China, ended this relative isolation of China. Contact with African countries was re-established, and the educational cooperation could continue. The post-Cultural Revolution economic situation in China, however, prevented the country from establishing itself as an important donor. The period from 1976 to 1982 is thus marked by limited external aid to Africa.

In September 1983, following the 12th Party Congress (September 1982) and Premier Zhao's subsequent visit to Africa, the cooperation increased substantially (Li, 2006). A broadening of China's re-engagement with Africa could be noticed through the increasing aid packages and the inclusion of African countries other than those that had traditionally been close to China. In relative terms, the education cooperation was still minor. Starting from a modest five African countries in the late 1950s, it reached 43 countries by the end of the 1980s (He, 2006).

2.2. Africa as a source of political support (1989–2000)

A second phase of educational cooperation, I argue, started in the 1990s. More specifically, this second phase of cooperation was initially linked to the violent events surrounding the Tiananmen Square in June 1989.[3] It should be underlined that the Tiananmen movement was inspired by the perestroika reforms introduced in June 1987 by the Soviet leader Mikhail Gorbachev. In 1989, China's relative isolation in the face of intense criticism from the West – coinciding with silence from various African countries – arguably led to the Chinese government's realization that Africa was a useful and manageable source of international support (Taylor, 2006). Many African leaders perhaps felt threatened by the West's post-Cold War discourse on human rights and democracy. In this, they found a degree of common ground with Beijing. The political events of 1989 thus provide the backdrop of the increasing cooperation between China and Africa in the 1990s, leading to the doubling of African students in China and the number of Chinese teachers in Africa. This boost was not only due to growing assistance to Africa from China: the number of self-funded African students studying in China increased from two in 1989 to 1580 in 1999 (He, 2006). During this period, Chinese and African Universities also increasingly sought to develop common research programs (He, 2006). Gradually, the need for Africa as a source of political support was complemented with the need of Africa as a source of natural resources (Taylor, 2006).

2.3. Increasing economic relationship (2000–present)

Presently, China is focused on the development of its international economic ties rather than on a diplomacy serving ideology (Tu, 2009). As Foreign Minister Yang Jiechi said on March 2009: "The focus of our diplomatic work should be ... to directly serve the economy ... Diplomacy should not be a zero-sum game, but one that strives to create win–win situations" (Xinhua, March 7, 2009). The first Forum on China–Africa Cooperation (FOCAC) in October 2000 increased the pace of this economic cooperation. The forum, according to China's Africa policy statement (FOCAC, 2006), has the aim to become a mechanism for dialogue and cooperation between China and Africa:

> Launched in 2000, the Forum on China–Africa Cooperation has become an effective mechanism for the collective dialogue and multilateral cooperation between China and Africa and put in place an important framework and platform for a new type of China–Africa partnership featuring long-term stability, equality and mutual benefit. ... China will work with African countries within the framework of the Forum to explore new ways to enhance mutual political trust, promote the comprehensive development of pragmatic cooperation, further improve the mechanism of the forum, and try to find the best way for furthering cooperation between the Forum and the NEPAD [New Partnership for Africa's Development] (FOCAC, 2006, p. 1).

Similar fora have (since 2000) been conducted every third year – in Africa and China alternatively, and according to interviewees (both in Beijing and in Cameroon), functions *in lieu* of a more permanent cooperation structure. A second forum was held in Addis Ababa in December 2003, and a third forum was convened in Beijing in November 2006, receiving unprecedented media attention because of the presence in Beijing of a considerable number of African leaders. This third forum was marked by an acceleration of the cooperation between China and Africa, as outlined in an Action Plan that provided a list of Sino-African aid and cooperation strategies, including a considerable development of the field of human resource building and support to education in Africa (FOCAC, 2006). For human resources development, it was claimed that following the 2004–2006 Sino-African Inter-governmental Human Resources Development Plan (adopted at the Second Forum), China had trained over 10,000 African professionals in various fields under its African Human Resources Development Fund (AHRDF). The Third Forum's Action Plan foresaw the continued training of an additional 15,000 professionals and management personnel for African countries (FOCAC, 2006). In terms of education, the Chinese Government would (i) help African countries set up 100 rural schools over the next 3 years; (ii) increase the number of the Chinese government's scholarships to African students from the current 2000 per year to 4000 per year by 2009; (iii) provide in-service training for educational officials and teachers of universities, primary, secondary and vocational schools in Africa; and (iv) establish Confucius Institutes in African countries (FOCAC, 2006). The fourth forum took place in Sharm El Sheikh, Egypt, on 8–9 November 2009, claimed that the prior phase had successfully achieved its targets, and can in many ways be seen as the continuation and consolidation of the third forum. The action plan established by the conference included the building of 50 China–Africa friendship schools, the set up of a new type of cooperation between universities, continue scholarships and other human capacity building programs, and continue the implementation of Confucius Institutes (FOCAC, 2009b).

In view of the limited public information about the Chinese aid and cooperation, and also because of the frequent overlapping of economic cooperation[4] and aid, it is difficult to estimate the

[2] The *Joint Communiqué of the United States of America and the People's Republic of China*, or the "Shanghai Communiqué" (1972), was a document pledging to normalize the relations between the USA and China. The document also expressed the wish to expand the economic and cultural cooperation between the two nations. The establishment of diplomatic relationship between the two countries followed seven years later.

[3] A number of students and intellectuals believed that the economic and political reforms initiated since 1978 by Deng Xiaoping had not gone far enough and that China needed to further reform its political system. The demonstrations at Tiananmen Square started as a mourning of the death of Hu Yaobang (6th General Secretary of the Communist Party of PRC), and lasted from Hu's death on 15 April until tanks violently cleared the square on 4 June. The number of deaths is not known. Interestingly, the movement is parallel to Anti-African protests in Nanjing and Beijing that started prior to Hu's death (Crane, 1994).

[4] For example, China includes support to Chinese companies to set up enterprises in Africa as a component of the aid.

importance of this aid. Davies et al. (2008, p. 7) in an attempt to quantify the aid noted that,

> Before the first FOCAC Summit, held in October 2000, China's bilateral aid commitments to Africa were minimal. ... Since 2000, China's development assistance to Africa has gained momentum. ...One senior official in China estimated that approximately $4.5 billion in aid had been disbursed to Africa in 2006. In comparison, official development assistance by the DAC members in 2006 to Africa amounted to $43.4 billion, up from $40.9 billion in 2005.

Chinese aid to African education is still relatively modest, but, as we shall see in the case study on Cameroon, it is starting to become more visible on the international aid and cooperation scene.

3. Cameroon's educational cooperation with China

China's policies towards Cameroon have gone through different stages, each connected to wider Sino-African and international political and economic realities, as outlined in the first section above. Cameroon, with a population of 18.5 million, of which 40% are under the poverty line, has modest oil resources and favorable agricultural conditions. The country severed its ties with the Taiwanese authorities and established a diplomatic relationship with China on 26 March 1971 (MOFA, 2003). A trade agreement was set up with Cameroon in 1972 – and a number of high-level visits took place in the 1970s. Medical aid (in the form of a number of doctors sent to Cameroon) started in 1975 and, according to the Chinese Ministry of Foreign Affairs (MOFA, 2003, p. 1), a policy of "mutual-benefit cooperation between China and Cameroon started from 1982." The education cooperation between the two countries became increasingly important since the 1990s, with the establishment of a Chinese Language Training Center in 1996 (transformed into a Confucius Center in 2007) at the University of Yaoundé II. The Institute has observed a growing interest for Chinese studies among Cameroonian students, with an increasing number of enrollments every year. Likewise, a steadily growing number of applications for scholarships given from China started to take off in the 1990s. Before that, scholarships were few, and correspondingly few Cameroonians were interested in pursuing their studies in China. In 2009, China emerges as the most important donor of scholarships (40 new scholarships in 2009), largely because students are allowed to attend training from bachelor level and upwards, whereas most DAC donors focus on Post-Doctoral seminars and training. One reason for this difference is related to China's visa and immigration policies, which are very different from Western countries' policies. As noted by a Chinese Embassy staff member interviewed during fieldwork, "our visa policy is not very strict as compared to France or the USA. People coming to China are not considered as illegal immigrants but as friendly ambassadors." Likewise, the training both in the Confucius Institute in Yaoundé and in China (through scholarships given to Cameroonians) has, according to interviewees, two distinct functions: the training is related to resource building and to cultural sensitizing about China ("building friendship"). Four types of Chinese education aid to Africa will be illustrated below, following the plan outlined by FOCAC (2006): Confucius Institutes, which are providing language and culture-related training in host countries; scholarships for Cameroonians in China; school construction, and stand-alone education projects.[5]

3.1. Chinese language training

The Confucius Institute (CI) in Yaoundé was inaugurated in 2007. Originally it was a Chinese Language Training Center that started up in 1996 as a cooperation project between a higher education institution in China, more precisely the Zhejiang Normal University, and in Cameroon, the International Relations Institute of Cameroon (IRIC), attached to University of Yaoundé II. The Chinese non-governmental organization (NGO) Hanban[6] officially took over the administration of the center on 9 November 2007. Originally the center focused on training students at IRIC for which Chinese was an optional language, together with Arabic and Spanish. The center also started to enroll other interested learners, in addition to its commitment to Yaoundé II students, when it was converted into a Confucius Institute (CI).

Since 2007, the CI has been very busy because the five full-time staff members (two Chinese teachers, two African teachers, and one administrative assistant), in addition to the language teaching, also (in the terms of a teacher) need to organize "colorful events to spread information about China's culture." As an example, I attended a Chinese karaoke competition for African students that celebrated the Chinese Spring Festival. Other events include a knowledge game labeled a "Bridge competition," which involves all of the Confucius Institutes worldwide. It consists of three parts, questioning participants on their knowledge to China's culture, language, and on a specific subject chosen every year. For example, in 2008, the specific theme was the Olympics. Also, a Chinese club meets every Wednesday afternoon to organize cultural activities, such as paper cutting, watching Chinese movies, learning Chinese songs, and discussing in Chinese. On Saturday mornings a Tai Chi class is organized.

The students from the public can attend three levels of Chinese language learning, whereas the IRIC students study the first semester, and then continue during a second year, also for the first semester. Further, since the IRIC is a center with sub-regional aspiration, the CI spreads interest for the Chinese language beyond Cameroon. According to a teacher, "the students in this [diplomatic] course come from various countries in the subregion, including Gabon, Central Africa, Chad and other countries." In general, according to interviewees (and supported by enrollment statistics), the interest for Chinese language is growing, and reflects the shift from an ideology-based interest in China's language and civilization towards an economic interest. This change fits with the larger and more generalized periods of Sino-African educational cooperation outlined by He in the first section above, i.e., the shift from political to economic cooperation noticed around 2000:

> We had very few learners in the beginning [1996]. Only four students were enrolled during the first year, of which two were girls, and four students during the second year. After that, the number of students improved. ... There is a very strong demand for learning Chinese now, more than 50 students per year. ...The students say that there are a lot of Chinese businesses here, and that they would like to facilitate the Chinese businesses by working as translators. Also, they believe that China is a super power in competition with the USA. Other students would like to do business with China (Interview with a CI teacher).

Interviews with students confirmed their interest in "doing business with China," or working as translators. After studying at the CI, the students can take a Chinese proficiency test, which is

[5] If no other reference is provided, the information is based on triangulation of observation and interview evidence as well as written records and documents.

[6] It should be noted that in China, "non-governmental" organizations like Hanban are closely linked to the Chinese administration. It is therefore not an NGO in the Western sense of the word.

functioning in a similar way as a Test Of English as a Foreign Language (TOEFL). In 2007, two students completed the test; in 2008, eight students; and in 2009 17 students (of which eight were girls). The growing interest for the Chinese language can also be exemplified through the number of institutions offering Chinese language learning. Hence, the newly opened University of Maroua in the North of Cameroon has recently opened a Confucius Institute. Additionally, in 2009, an annex of the Yaoundé Confucius Institute opened in Douala, Cameroon's economic capital. In January 2010, China Culture Organization featured an article outlining the growing interest for Chinese language in Cameroon:

> Yaounde's Superior Normal School ... now [has] 1565 students who have chosen to study Chinese. Three other branches are at the University of Buea, Saint-Andre School in Douala and the Senior Commerce School in Yaounde. According to the vice president of the Confucius Institute in Cameroon [Yaoundé II], Zhang Xiaozhen, a professor sent by the Zhejiang Normal University in China, the institute has seen exceptional growth in the last 2 years. "We are overwhelmed, the number of students does not stop increasing. Businessmen, Cameroonian public servants and other members of the private sector are all coming to us to learn Chinese," Zhang said. "At the beginning of September semester, we had about 3000 students in total who had been registered. And the number of teachers, both Chinese and Cameroonian, got to about 20," she added (Liu Fang, 2010, p. 1).

Similarly, the Ministry of Secondary Education has expressed interest in a future offering of Chinese as an optional language in Cameroonian schools.

3.2. Scholarships and human resource building

The scholarship cooperation with China took off in 1995. Before that, Cameroon rarely received scholarships, but as noted by a staff of the Scholarship Commission, "at that point China emerged, the communist area took an end, and people started to get interested." The fact that China performed so well economically stimulated a lot of interest. As noted by the Chinese Embassy in Yaoundé,

> In the 1950s and 1960s the students went to China for political reasons, and 100% of them returned to their country of origin. But all this has changed with the economic development of China. Now the students are trying to stay in China just the same way as the Chinese students studying in Europe try to stay in Europe.

During the last 6 years Cameroon received between 20 and 35 scholarships from China annually. In 2009, the offer was 40 places, placing China as the first scholarship donor, followed by Morocco and Algeria. Usually the students enter at bachelor level – and can reapply after obtaining the first degree to continue to Master's level. Most of the students reapply to continue higher studies when they have completed the first scholarship period. The students select their subject and the university they wish to attend, based on a list of available universities. Science, IT and economics are the most popular subjects, but Chinese Embassy personnel (which is coordinating the scholarship program with the Ministry of Higher Education) also request that a number of students interested in studying Chinese language and culture should be offered places:

> The students going to China favor economics, industry and IT studies. Very few are involved in cultural studies. I sort of imposed cultural studies for at least four places this year, to promote the Chinese language.

Staff at the Scholarship Commission underlined that there is a language and cultural barrier in China that African students going to Europe do not encounter. Some students in China complained about isolation and in certain cases ostracism, or even outright racism. It should be recalled that the Tiananmen Square demonstrations followed anti-African demonstrations among Chinese students in Hehai University in Nanjing (Crane, 1994). However, with the increasing number of Africans in China, it seems as if the relationships have improved:

> It is easy for Cameroonian students to integrate in Europe. However, students going to China are complaining about isolation. ... The number of African students is increasing in China, so they generally feel less and less isolated.

Personnel at the Ministry of Higher Education's Scholarship Commission indicated that the earlier integration problems are largely solved: currently there is even a Cameroonian student association in China. During fieldwork focus group settings, however, the students often asked me about ostracism in China. They had heard former or current African students in China complaining about such problems. Despite these issues of isolation and ostracism, the interest for studying in China has multiplied: a few years ago, only 40–50 candidates applied for the scholarships, of which half received an offer. Sometimes the scholarship commission had to investigate applicants for other scholarships to obtain enough candidates to go to China, and thus suggested to students who had applied for scholarships for Morocco or some other country, that they could go to China instead. Currently, for 2008 and 2009, the situation has changed substantially, and the commission received 350 requests for the scholarships to China. As noted by an interviewee, "Now, we're in the inverse situation; there are too many applicants."

A number of Cameroonian students go to China to study, using their own money or relying on their family's financial support. Often they revert to the Embassy when their funds run out: this problem is so common that the Cameroonian embassy in Beijing has a specific budget to deal with it. It is straightforward for self-funded students to go to China because of the ease to obtain a visa. Although neither the scholarship commission nor the Embassy has exact numbers, both estimate that currently there are an equal number of Cameroonian self-funded and scholarship students in China. The Chinese Embassy in Yaoundé said, "there are maybe 30 or 40 self-funded students going to China every year." Many of the students, after finishing their studies, find employment in China. Also, for those coming back, Chinese companies based in Cameroon may employ them. The Ministry of Higher Education does not have an overview of the further employment of Cameroonian students with a Chinese education, but noted that:

> They do not come back to the Ministry to tell that they are back, or that they are unemployed. We believe that either they remain in China or that they come back and get employment straightaway in Cameroon.

Currently, Cameroon receives scholarships, not only from the Chinese government, but also from independent institutions in China. For example, the Ministry of Higher Education recently received an offer from the Beijing municipality of five places in the University of Economics in Beijing. It was an offer of payment of

school fees, and all the other fees needed to be paid by the student. Since a number of students already are going to China to study without scholarships, the Ministry was happy to accept these offers. Generally, the same evolution is noted with scholarships as with the Chinese language training in Cameroon: the cooperation increased substantially in importance in the 1990s, prior to which it was limited to political exchanges. In the 1990s, with the boom in China, the public increasingly became aware of China as a new international economic power. Hence, interest for China, Chinese language studies, and studies *in* China increased in parallel to China's new economic visibility.

In addition to the long-term scholarships, the Chinese are also providing short-term training to Cameroon and every year finance between 100 and 110 study tours in China for technicians and civil servants. Chinese authorities offer two types of training, technician training which is longer and last between 6 months and a year, and training for civil servants, which usually lasts about 2–3 weeks. In 2008, approximately 60 Cameroonian civil servants and 30 technicians were trained. They went to different places in China, depending on the theme of the training. In general, the trainees and training type are selected by the Cameroonians, based on a list of offers from the Chinese Ministry of Higher Education. As noted by an Embassy staff member, "the global goal for this 3-year period [i.e., FOCAC, 2006 goals] is to train 30,000 people from Africa and Latin America, but we don't have a target number for each country." In general, the Chinese Embassy is involved in the organization and coordination of the short-term training.

3.3. School construction

Traditionally, China has been – and is – involved in large infrastructure-building projects in Africa. Hence, Chinese companies have been involved in road building in Cameroon, and have also constructed several sports complexes (*Palais des Sports*) as well as administrative buildings. Until the 2006 FOCAC promise of building 100 primary schools in Africa, however, the Chinese were not much involved in basic education:

> The cooperation with China began in 2006, so it's very recent. China's aid is organized by events [*la Chine agit par à-coup*]. In 2006, we received a project for the construction of a single primary school as a result of the visit of the Cameroonian president to China... In 2007, the Chinese president visited Cameroon, and we received two primary schools (Interview with a civil servant in the Ministry of Basic Education).

In 2009 the Chinese completed the building of three primary schools (out of a total of 100 promised to Africa at the Third FOCAC). The Cameroonian Ministry of Basic Education found the cooperation with the Chinese so promising that a specific unit dealing with Japanese and Chinese Projects has been set up within the Ministry. The head of the Chinese section has spent 5 years studying in China, and is fluent in Chinese. She explained, "The Chinese cooperation is at its beginning phase.... We aim at setting up the same type of coordination with China as we have with Japan."

For primary school construction (as with other projects), the Chinese cooperation can be said to be in the "response mode" (King, 2009). Accordingly, Cameroonians selected the location where the schools were to be built, and then the Chinese, according to an interviewee at the Cooperation Unit, "did everything, including using their own architectural style." The Chinese Embassy explained that the construction of schools is financed by a gift from China that Cameroon "does not need to reimburse." The Chinese authorities organize a bidding process in China to hire a Chinese enterprise to build the school. This is, according to the embassy, "part of a win–win situation" since it produces international employment for Chinese enterprises. The prospective enterprises need to have an authorization from the Chinese government to participate in the bidding process, certifying that they are capable of implementing an international project. Apparently, according to an Embassy interviewee, "thousands of enterprises meet this qualification." These enterprises can be private, owned by civil society associations, or they can be state enterprises. There is no limitation as far as the type of association is concerned. In Cameroon, three enterprises were selected for the construction of the three schools – and at least one of them was private.

Japan is the largest bilateral donor for school construction in Cameroon. Generally, the Chinese use more of their own experts and workers in the construction process, whereas the Japanese generally makes use of a local subcontractor who will do the actual construction under supervision of Japanese experts. The technicians are all local people. In contrast, the Chinese use technicians from China together with local workers. Materials are brought from China or purchased in Cameroon. The Cameroonian control engineers that were following up on the construction, found the Chinese construction norms perplexing:

> We have a French education and we use French norms. What is irritating with the Chinese is that they use Chinese norms. We find these norms less rigorous than our norms.

However, it was also noted that the Japanese had been studying the Cameroonian environment and pedagogical needs for many years, and had succeeded, over time, in adapting the school buildings to Cameroonian needs and norms, whereas "China is still a beginner" in terms of development cooperation:

> China has therefore not yet normalized the design of school buildings, and is working with provisional norms in order to complete existing projects (Interview with a Cameroonian Control Engineer).

The same situation apparently took place with the Japanese cooperation; the Japanese also needed a learning phase before they came up with a standardized and effective school building approach. In pointing to this need for a learning phase, it is clear that the Ministry of Basic Education in Cameroon is expecting that the Chinese school construction program will expand in parallel with other types of Sino-Cameroonian cooperation.

3.4. An example of higher education cooperation: the microbiology project

In 1993, a convention was signed between University of Yaoundé I and the University of Zhejiang (ZJU) for student exchange and research cooperation in the field of sciences and microbiology. Under this cooperation, which is still ongoing (albeit not very significant at present), a number of students left to China, and also a number of teachers received training in China. In 1993, 10 academic staff came from China with the objective to help local students at master's level. The main phase of the program focused on microbiology and lasted from 1993 to 1997. In the beginning, the cooperation encountered some difficulties related to the cultural differences between the Chinese professors and the Cameroonians. A professor stated that "the Chinese didn't speak with us; they spoke among themselves. They were always calm." However, to find a solutions of these problems, it was agreed that instead of

Chinese professors supervising Cameroonian students alone, they would co-supervise students together with a Cameroonian staff. Such co-supervisory arrangements apparently improved the cooperation and understanding between the two teams. In all, 10 Master degrees, 13 DEA [*diplôme d'études approfondies*, or "diploma of advanced studies" (MPhil equivalent)], and five Ph.D.'s were submitted and successfully defended as a part of the cooperation. The Chinese also equipped the university with a microbiology laboratory. After 1997, both Chinese and Cameroonian authorities sought to extend this very successful cooperation, through the creation of a Research Institute for Applied Use of Medicinal Plants. However, this new project encountered a number of administrative, cultural and economic problems, including problems with the communication between the Chinese and Cameroonian negotiation teams, and has therefore not yet been implemented.

The cooperation, despite the problems encountered, illustrates facets of Chinese policies in education and human resource building. The Chinese seem to be looking for practical activities, and a hands-on, "mutual-benefit" cooperation. A Cameroonian microbiology professor noted that,

> The teaching is not theoretical but very practical. We felt that the Chinese were more practical than experts from other countries, and that they considered the direct use of the research in the fields of agriculture and health.

4. Policies and perception of Sino-Cameroonian cooperation

In looking at the various approaches and types of cooperation, a pattern emerges: first – the Chinese aid to Cameroon is visibly on the rise. Second, the cooperation is still in a beginning phase, and is still being organized to a large extent by the involvement of the Chinese Embassy, not by professional development and aid workers. Third, the cooperation is trying to provide demand-driven, practical, useful aid to Cameroon – which can be of mutual-benefit for the two countries; hence the emphasis on "win–win." Finally, the cooperation is largely based on programmatic events, such as the FOCAC. In the two sections below, I first outline the policies of Chinese involvement in Cameroon – and then the perception of the cooperation and aid.

4.1. Chinese aid and cooperation policies

As noted above, the aid and cooperation policies and strategies are largely based on the FOCAC process. Therefore, it can be said that the Sino-African aid and cooperation strategy is based on 3-year programs. Most of the aid and cooperation projects are decided as an exchange between two countries during FOCAC or during some other high-level meeting. As noted by the Chinese Embassy in Yaoundé:

> We are trying to make a strategic plan, a long-term plan. Every third year, the interministerial forum [FOCAC] evaluates the actions, and makes plans for new actions. For example we decided to construct schools. In the years to come, we will evaluate whether we should continue to give support in the same sector. These decisions are taken during the meetings of the forum.

The principles of the cooperation are said to be related to African needs, and secondly, to help in domains that the Chinese are capable to help them in; hence the focus on practical aid projects, rather than the use of conditionalities and a meta-narrative on, for example, structural adjustment or economic policies, human rights, the environment,[7] or other themes that are often being promoted by the Western donors.

This type of aid is characterized by the limited possibilities of the Embassy to follow-up on the aid and cooperation. As noted in the introduction, China distinguishes itself in not having a central institution coordinating aid, nor professional aid workers that are in charge of the follow-up of the cooperation projects. It follows that China generally doesn't fund any regional projects, only particular projects in each country. It is interesting to note that the Chinese Embassy in Cameroon has been participating in meetings with the other donors at the World Bank to discuss the economic situation for aid and cooperation. Also, Chinese Embassy representatives participated in an Education For All sector meeting at UNESCO-Yaoundé. Also, the Embassy expressed a wish to streamline Chinese aid with other donors' aid, and to co-implement projects with UN agencies:

> The China–Africa aid politics are a bit special. We don't have joint projects within international agencies, but only bilateral arrangements. In the future, we hope to make joint programs and projects with the World Bank, UNICEF and UNESCO. For the moment, our only cooperation with these agencies is at the level of exchange of information.

The Embassy in Yaoundé has only two key staff members following up on the aid and cooperation projects (in education and other domains), and who are also performing regular consular functions. Such low number of staff limits the capacity of the Embassy to conduct a realistic monitoring of the aid program and of implementing a structured and coherent aid policy. The lack of human resources for follow-up also has its repercussions in terms of project documentation. Often, China has been criticized by the West about its limited transparency and of lack of documentation regarding the aid and cooperation projects. However, it should be emphasized that China has only recently emerged as a donor, and the Chinese institutions have not yet had time to adjust to the dramatic increase in aid and cooperation that took place after the first (2000) FOCAC:

> Our statistic services are not very good, and we have yet not established a very good data system. ... Chinese aid and cooperation with Africa have been hindered by a lack of transparency, and a lot of the documentation on prior projects has been lost. The new strategy of aid to foreign countries is important for us, and we are currently reviewing old projects and practices, to learn for the future (Embassy Personnel, Yaoundé).

The personnel in the Embassies mostly follow-up on an aid and cooperation agenda that is already set at a high political level. For example, they will every year receive a list of training seminars from the Chinese Ministry of Higher Education, which they pass on to the Ministry of Higher Education in Cameroon. Then they will follow-up on the selection and process the names and visa applications for the chosen participants. Some of this training, especially short-term training, clearly has a diplomatic goal rather than providing capacity building. A Chinese official criticized the selection of short-term trainees as biased, and said that,

[7] Although it should be noted that the recent FOCAC (2009b, p. 3) "underline[s] in particular African countries' urgent need for stronger capacity to adapt to climate change and support their legitimate right in combating climate change." It also discusses the effect of the worldwide economic slowdown that started in the fall of 2008, and supports African efforts to reach the Millennium Development Goals.

> ...the Ministry send their family and friends to the training. Teachers and real people don't go; only administrators. It's really desperate, they go away and come back without [having learnt] anything ... and they just have some pictures and souvenirs that they have bought.

However, it should be underlined that this is not a situation that is specific to the Chinese aid and cooperation. It is a Cameroonian problem, linked to the lack of transparency in the administration of scholarships. As noted by an Embassy interviewee, "I have talked to the US Embassy about this problem, and the US Embassy has exactly the same stories and the same problem." Nevertheless, the Chinese aid and cooperation administration in its lack of resources, and in its principles of non-conditionality, may have even less control than other donors over the Cameroonians' use of funding and the selection of personnel to be trained. Added to this comes a Chinese cultural near-aversion to request accountability for the aid offered. For example, the Embassy is donating US$10,000 worth in IT equipment to the Ministry of Secondary Education every year. The equipment is intended to be distributed to schools, but there is no control that this distribution is effectively taking place. As noted by a Chinese official,

> ... this is not a good way of operating. We have no control over how they use the equipment. If we offer it directly to the schools, the Ministry would be offended. We feel it is not polite to control the use of the equipment. But we fear that the equipment will not serve its intention.

In addition to the cooperation between governments, a number of cooperation projects are set up between private institutions. Up to the 1990s, the government financed all the Chinese international projects, but around 1995, some private companies started to implement projects. Since in China many companies operate under the umbrella of a university, it can be difficult for the recipient country to determine whether the aid and cooperation is part of an official agreement, or if it is an institutional deal sought by a private partner. The Chinese Embassy in Yaoundé explained that "there is even a possibility that mixed or private companies are operating under the same name as the university. These companies can offer cooperation projects to foreign countries." The Embassy does not necessarily know which companies are doing what in Cameroon, but in many cases they are asked to help in the negotiation between the company and the country's host institution. Hence, there could in some cases be confusion between the public and private of China's development aid. The aforementioned microbiology project is a good example; it started out as an institutional cooperation project between two universities, which was facilitated by the Chinese Embassy (which was involved in the negotiations between the institutions). The extension phase (which is currently stalled) would bring in a private Chinese company for the installation of a production facility to transform medical plants into medicine. The Cameroonians said they were unsure of the expertise provided by the Chinese (i.e., whether the Chinese would dispatch professors or factory specialists to help the implementation of the project), and how the modalities of the cooperation would be carried out, e.g., who would own any patents that may come out of the research. Again, this situation takes us back to the novelty of the strong Chinese involvement in Africa, and the rapid expansion of the Sino-African aid and cooperation, which maybe has precluded a more organized and systematic approach.

4.2. Cameroonian perception of Chinese aid

A number of different attitudes and reactions can be distinguished among the Cameroonian aid recipients. First, a limited number of Cameroonians found the aid to be exploitative and aligned to other donors' excessive approaches. Often, these officials point to negotiating techniques employed by the Chinese that they find "unfair," and complain about the Embassy's involvement in institution-to-institution negotiations. Also, interviewees at the Prime Minister's office pointed out that the Chinese look for raw materials and that the aid is tied to economic conditionalities: "the Chinese are very shrewd and come with things that we like. They give us a stadium; we give them an oil well."[8] Conversely, other politicians pointed out that when the traditional donors started to ask for transparency in the cooperation, as well as "democracy and other conditionalities," China was preferred as donor, because of its lack of involvement in the recipient country's internal affairs: "So, at the time of structural adjustments, we prefer dealing with the Chinese because they do not ask for transparency or that we respect ethnic minorities in our country." Other interviewees (also politicians, education managers) pointed out that the conditionalities imposed by Western donors did not have any impact, and that the interchange with the Chinese therefore represented a "true dialogue:"

> The politicians prefer the Chinese discourse because they [the Chinese] don't begin the dialogue with discussion of conditionalities. Conditionalities are not a cure for everything. After 1990, human rights and democracy became conditionalities for aid. Therefore, new laws declared the principles of human rights and democracy, but nobody applied these laws.

A number of Cameroonian politicians and administrators find the aid and cooperation from China "better" than the aid from traditional donors, because a colonial past does not hamper it. Also, China's own development is seen as a model for development.[9] In comparing the differences between three types of bilateral aid (from China, France and Norway), a senior advisor to the Prime Minister explained:

> Norway let us steer towards the areas of intervention that we felt were appropriate and needed in Cameroon. France would never have let us steer the process ... China, on the other hand, is more calculating. China would like to give you something, but they would like something in return. The Norwegian cooperation is generous. Psychologically, the difference between the two styles is very important. China has good intentions, but wants something in return. France would like to be generous, but there is a background of a debt to pay, of a re-compensation for something. The relation is like an adult towards a child.

Also, he noted that behind its apparent generosity, France has an agenda for the French culture, and the *Francophonie*. In analyzing policies of human resource building, it was noted that France does not give scholarships to any initial education at bachelor level, but only to post-graduate and research purposes. Other Western countries are following the same pattern, and rather give scholarships to postgraduate students. This makes it possible for the donor country to consider the mature students; if they are very good, they can be kept in the host country. If they are

[8] This was meant figuratively. As far as I could figure out, the Chinese had not been given an oil well in Cameroon.

[9] See my analysis of China as a model along the lines of a "Beijing Consensus" in Nordtveit (2009).

arriving to the donor country when they are too young, they don't want to go back to Cameroon, whereas older people with a family are willing to go back. In this way, the West gets "the better of two worlds: it keeps the best, and returns the rest." China, on the other hand, has a policy of opening-up towards other countries, and therefore gives scholarships at bachelor level.

Some Cameroonian officials were frustrated by the lack of responsiveness from the Chinese Embassy. Since China does not have an organized aid structure, or any specific person in charge of aid at the Embassy, a number of requests from specific ministries apparently remain unanswered. At the Ministry of Basic Education, officials said that they had requested school construction and training, but had so far only received 10 refrigerators and 20 TV sets:

> There is no plan or sign of cooperation; so we are following up on political events, which are usually accompanied by aid. The Chinese are approaching us to offer projects, but they do not take into account our requests. For example, we have no reply to a request made in 2005–2006 for the construction of primary schools and kindergartens. The embassy has been very helpful and given us 10 refrigerators and 20 TV sets. However, we feel that China does not have any institution that follows up on aid. Even our plans for training in China have not materialized. We have asked for training for teachers at preschool level but we have not received any reply.

UNESCO representatives in Cameroon noted that China is providing aid to the education sector through their engagements in school construction, and that the Embassy of China was for the first time present in a technical and financial meeting between UNESCO, financial partners, and the Ministry of Education in January 2009. UNESCO thinks that China will increase its aid to Cameroon ["*la Chine devrait arriver*"] because of having announced its intentions to augment its aid to the sector. However, it was also noted that little was known about Chinese cooperation in education. Other donors and organizations shared this view. For example, a representative from the NGO Network For EFA said that "Chinese construction of schools is not well known by civil society. ... China's engagement with Cameroon should be public knowledge." In particular, it was emphasized that, in view of the severe problem of corruption in Cameroon, it is very important that China is transparent with the money it is giving in aid:

> Our role as civil society is to have a look at how the money is used. ... Cameroon is one of the most corrupt countries in the world. For example, we can plan to construct a school somewhere, and then some politician will "take" the school and build it somewhere else [most often, in the home town or election base of the politician].

This had apparently happened with the Chinese school construction projects in many African countries (including Cameroon), since an interviewee in Beijing complained that the school construction project in Africa was at risk, because of high officials' "hijacking" of the schools. Civil society representatives in Cameroon further emphasized that "if China is only dealing with the Cameroonian government bilaterally, it will increase the problems of corruption that we face in the country."

5. Conclusion

The Sino-Cameroonian educational cooperation illustrates facets of China's development engagement with Africa. First, one notes a clear transition from a political engagement phase to a more economic driven phase that can be dated to the period of opening-up policies preceding the first FOCAC (in 2000). The transition is visible both from the Cameroonian and the Chinese side: increasingly Cameroonians are interested in China because of the economic development of the country. Conversely, China is interested in a "mutually beneficial" economic cooperation in Africa. Second, the support has recently changed pace – and China is therefore increasingly visible among the donors to education in Cameroon. Third, China is interested in enhanced cooperation with other education donors and aid agencies in Cameroon.

The analysis of various Chinese education projects in Cameroon demonstrates that China is a new donor – with particular problems and weaknesses related to its quick expansion of the aid and development sector: absence of a professional aid and coordination structure, ad-hoc replies to demands, unstructured aid that does not always correspond to the needs of the recipient.[10] Kenneth King, in a recent study of China's educational aid to Kenya (2010), also found similar characteristics of Chinese aid, which is said to be "on a learning curve."

During the fieldwork, I noted the openness and interest of staff at the Chinese Embassy to position themselves in the international donor coordination structures, and to improve their own implementation, monitoring, and reporting systems. China's involvement in Cameroon therefore seems to be slowly changing in nature, as the Chinese Embassy has been increasingly present and visible during education coordination meetings organized by UNESCO, the World Bank, or the Cameroonian Government. Also, the Chinese Embassy has confirmed its current information-sharing interest with DAC donors, and its willingness to coordinate with bilateral and multilateral initiatives; and even to co-finance projects. The Cameroonian stance seem to echo the discourse of the new FOCAC summit and the Declaration of Sharm El Sheikh (2009a), which seem to move towards a discourse aligned with other donors. In particular, the declaration "call on the developed countries to further assist African countries to achieve the UN Millennium Development Goals" (p. 2) as well as makes a commitment to "make sure that Africa's endeavor to achieve the Millennium Development Goals will not be reversed" (p. 4). Further, the declaration "oppose[s] protectionism in all its forms, and stand[s] to uphold an open and free trade and investment environment" as well as commits the partners to "continue to advance the Doha Round of trade negotiations" (p. 3).

Similar characteristic does not seem to be shared in all African countries: Kenneth King, in the aforementioned study of China's educational aid to Kenya (2010) found that China did not plan to harmonize its procedures with other donors in Kenya and that it upheld a distinct discourse among the donors. Up till now, China has distinguished herself by a discourse based on notions of "win–win," friendship and non-interference. The main political commitment of African countries seems to be linked to the "one China policy and support for China's peaceful reunification" (FOCAC, 2009a, p. 5). However, this situation may change if the FOCAC process becomes a tool to monitor China's delivery on pledges against specific agendas, including the Millennium Development Goals, in which case "China will run the risk of being perceived as an aid donor rather than in its preferred role of being seen as a large developing country involved, to the best of its ability, in South–South cooperation with other developing countries" (King, 2009, pp. 3–4). It will be interesting to see whether China in the future will keep its distinct vocabulary or if it instead gradually aligns its discourse and practices with the traditional donor groups.

[10] For example, a somewhat puzzled professor at the University of Yaoundé I told me that his department had received a shipment of umbrellas from the Chinese.

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